

Home Safety Assessment

CMT: CMT-0004 (SR)

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Introduction

The Home Safety Assessment is an evaluation of the patient's home to determine whether the environment is manageable, given the patient's functional abilities. A review is made of actual or potential hazards that can result in injury to the patient or caregiver. ADL, IADL, and psychosocial status ability should be assessed, since they impact injury potential. Safety issues within the home environment include the physical structure of the home (eg, steps, lighting, bathroom access), medication effects, fall risk factors, and the caregiver's potential to provide physical and emotional support.(1)(2) The patient and caregiver should be involved in home safety awareness to identify and remedy factors impacting safety in their environment.

The home safety assessment is usually performed by a case manager or home care agency staff (eg, RN, PT) and ideally is performed before the transition of care so proactive planning can take place.(3)(4) The assessment can also be completed during the initial home visit. After the assessment is performed, a plan is made to eliminate the safety risks and assist the patient in achieving optimal health. The plan is implemented to provide injury and readmission risk reduction. The plan may include a referral to a physical therapist, occupational therapist, social worker, or other home healthcare professional to address safety issues.(5)(6)(7)

The Home Safety Assessment lists general safety considerations and factors. Special considerations for pediatric and elderly patients are listed separately. The Home Safety Assessment may be used as a tool to assess safety risks in the patient's home.(8)

Additional assessment tools may be appropriate for use to assess home safety risk, including:

- Activities of Daily Living (ADL) and Instrumental Activities of Daily Living (IADL) Assessment  SR
- Psychosocial Assessment  SR
- Social Determinants of Health Screening Tool  SR

Home Safety Assessment

Safety Factors

- **Communication**(9)
 - Reliable telephone is close and easy to use, with access to emergency services.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Family, caregivers, friends, or neighbors can be reached if needed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Non-English-speaking patient has access to interpreter.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Emergencies**
 - First aid kit is current and has instructions.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable

- Emergency medical identification is worn or carried.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Plans to manage during emergencies common to region are in place (eg, earthquakes, floods, tornadoes).(10)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Facility: Exterior(2)(8)**
 - Wheelchair or walking assistance device is accessible (ie, adequate door width and ramps).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Stairs or steps have handrails.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Snow and ice removal plan is in place; surfaces are nonslip.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Pathways are clear and even.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Doors and windows are in good repair and can be locked.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Lighting is adequate.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Facility: Interior(2)(8)**
 - Patient is able to use stairs, or elevator or lift is available.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Stairs have accessible secure handrails, are clear to view, are well lit, are not too steep or narrow, and carpets are absent or securely attached.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Tub and shower safety devices are available, including nonskid mat, hand grips, or grab bars.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Toilet is accessible, at appropriate height, and with grab bars as needed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Medicine cabinet is well lit, in a cool dry place, and not available to children.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Doors are wide enough for wheelchair or walking device.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Hot and cold running water is available from a reliable source with hot water tank set below 120 degrees F (48.9 degrees C).
 - Yes
 - No

- Not applicable
- Halls and rooms are free of obstacles and clutter.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Rugs and floors are nonskid, frayed carpet edges have been removed, or carpets are securely attached.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Sleeping pets are out of pathways.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Chairs and other seats are stable and at a height to facilitate easy rising, and chair cushions are attached securely.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Environment is clean and free of pests, rodents, and garbage.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Adequate lighting is available, including night-lights and flashlights.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Light switches are easy to find and reach.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Heating and cooling units are in good repair.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Electrical appliances, cords, and outlets are safe, used appropriately, and in good repair.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Sufficient food is available, within reach, and can be prepared.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Refrigerator is available and sufficiently cold.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Stove is in good repair and accessible.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Ventilation is adequate.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Fall Risk Evaluation**(11)(12)(13)
 - Patient has mobility and function impairment (eg, poor balance, hemiplegia).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Patient has poor health or weakness.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable

- Patient has comorbidities that may increase risk (eg, stroke, brain injury, dementia).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient has sensory or cognitive loss (eg, memory loss, poor judgment, visual or hearing loss, aphasia).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient is incontinent.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient is taking 4 or more prescription medications.[A](5)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient has had recent changes in dosage or number of prescription medications.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient is prescribed medications that increase fall risk (ie, benzodiazepines, sedative-hypnotics, antidepressants, or antipsychotics).(13)(16)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient uses drugs that impact balance or cognition (eg, alcohol, opiates).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Fire Safety(8)**
 - Fire extinguisher is functional.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Smoke detector(s) are functioning, and there is a plan to change the battery regularly and on each floor.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Fireplace is in good condition, with screen, and chimney is cleaned regularly.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Smoking habits are as safe as possible.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Auxiliary electrical and heating units are away from flammable material.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Evacuation plan in event of fire is in place, including available exits.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Patient and caregiver know how to drop and roll to extinguish flames if clothes are on fire.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Medical Equipment(17)**
 - Oxygen safety precautions are in place.(18)
 - Yes
 - No

- Not applicable
- Medical equipment is in good repair.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient and caregiver know how to use and clean equipment safely.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Backup plan exists for essential medical equipment in event of breakage or power outage.(18)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Phone numbers of equipment rental or management companies are easily accessible.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Medication(7)**
 - Medication is stored properly, in a dry, cool, dark place or refrigerator, as indicated.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Medications are clearly labeled with name of patient, dosage, frequency, and route of administration.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Outdated or hazardous medication has been removed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Patient or caregiver is able to dispose of biological waste and sharps in accordance with local ordinances.(19)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Safeguards are in place against falls when medications that increase fall risk are prescribed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- **Miscellaneous(20)**
 - Guns or weapons are stored safely in a locked site with key available only to appropriate adults, and ammunition is locked up separately.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Patient and caregiver demonstrate understanding of infection control and universal precautions, including hand-washing techniques.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Vision has been checked, eyeglass prescription is up to date, eyeglass lenses are clean, and eyeglasses are available as needed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
 - Carbon monoxide detector(s) are functioning, and there is a plan to change the battery regularly and on each floor.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable

Special considerations for seniors

- Patient rises slowly from sitting or lying positions as needed.
 - Yes

- No
 - Not applicable
- Patient uses night-lights or turns on lights for nocturnal trips to bathroom.(20)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Written material and instructions are readable (eg, large print).
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Telephone has accommodations for impaired hearing or vision.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- If safety hazard cannot be removed, information has been provided on how to minimize risk.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient takes caution or uses devices for dizziness, imbalance, or gait abnormalities.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient uses walking aid or other assistive devices safely.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Patient wears supportive shoes with nonskid soles.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Medication management system is used, including reminder systems, prefilled boxes or syringes, and magnification to read fine print.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable

Special considerations for pediatrics

- Sleeping arrangements are appropriate and sanitary.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Painted cribs, bassinets, and high chairs were made after 1978.[B](21)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Crib is clean and safe, including snug mattress and slats 2 3/8 inches (6 cm) or less apart.(22)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Electrical outlets are covered and cords hidden.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- There are safety catches on cabinet doors and drawers.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Doors and windows are locked or screened, and non-accordion-type toddler gates are in place for stairs, at top and bottom, and open spaces.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable

- Poison prevention practices are observed, including reduction in number of toxic products, and poisons are kept out of reach or in locked cupboards.(20)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Cleaning products and poisons are in their original containers, not in food or beverage containers, and household products have childproof packages if available.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- No child has access to hanging objects, strings, or plastic bags.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- No child has access to balloons or small objects and toys.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Infant toys have no buttons, beads, or objects that can be pulled off and swallowed.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Common household appliances, sharp objects, hot objects, vitamins, prescription and nonprescription medication, and alcohol are out of reach.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Irritants in home are limited, including smoke, dust, molds, allergens, insects, and dampness.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Appropriate bathroom facilities are available, and hand washing is reinforced.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Play is appropriately supervised, especially in areas where child can climb, such as kitchen and bathrooms.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Heating and cooling ventilation openings are covered.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Outside play equipment is safe, free from rust, splinters, and sharp edges, and pool has fencing at least 4 feet (1.2 meters) high on all sides.(23)(24)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- First aid for children is available.
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Ipecac has been discarded.(25)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- The poison control center phone number is available and posted near telephone(s).(20)
 - Yes
 - No
 - Not applicable
- Parents and caregivers know child CPR.(26)
 - Yes

- No
- Not applicable

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Footnotes

[A] The number and type of medications consumed by the elderly increases the risk of falls and should be evaluated.(14)(15) [A in Context Link 1]

[B] Paint used before 1978 may contain lead, which causes developmental issues when ingested by children.(21) [B in Context Link 1]

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